CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

First Bull Run

Both sides thought the war would be short and glorious. One July afternoon in Virginia taught them otherwise. 1861.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Both sides thought the war would be short and glorious. One July afternoon in Virginia taught them otherwise. 1861.

Why did people in 1861 believe the war would be over in ninety days — and what does it cost a nation to be that wrong?

“On to Richmond!”

SUMMER 1861

After Sumter, both sides were sure of a quick victory. Northern newspapers demanded the army march on the Confederate capital at Richmond and end the rebellion in one blow. Enlistments were for just ninety days — no one expected to need longer.

In July 1861, an inexperienced Union army marched into Virginia to meet an equally green Confederate army near a creek called Bull Run, close to the railroad junction of Manassas.

“Battle of Bull Run, July 21, 1861” — hand-colored lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Picnic Battle

A BATTLE AS SPECTACLE

So certain were Washingtonians of an easy win that civilians rode out with picnic baskets to watch the battle from nearby hills, as if it were a sporting event.

At first the Union seemed to be winning. Then Confederate reinforcements arrived by train — one of the first times railroads decided a battle — and a Virginia general named Thomas Jackson held his line so firmly he earned the nickname “Stonewall.”

“The First Battle of Bull Run” — engraving, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Rout at Bull Run

JULY 21, 1861

The Union advance collapsed into a panicked retreat, tangling with the fleeing picnickers on the road back to Washington. The ‘short war’ died on this field.

“Battle of Bull Run, July 21, 1861” — hand-colored lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

“The First Battle of Bull Run”

THE RECKONING

Another artist's view of the same day. For a public that had packed picnic baskets, the retreat was the first proof that this war would be neither short nor glorious.

“The First Battle of Bull Run” — engraving, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Different War Than Anyone Expected

THE RECKONING

The Union retreat turned into a chaotic rout. Nearly 900 men were dead and thousands wounded — a shocking number for a country that had pictured a bloodless parade.

The lesson landed hard on both sides. The North realized it would need a huge, trained, long-term army, not ninety-day volunteers. The South, dangerously, grew overconfident. Everyone now understood: this would be long, and it would be terrible.

The divided nation, 1861 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

A UNION SOLDIER, AFTER THE BATTLE

I now know what a battle is … the men who went out so gay and confident came back a mob.

The End of the Illusion

WHY IT MATTERS

Bull Run changed nothing on the map — but it changed how both nations thought. Lincoln signed calls for hundreds of thousands of three-year volunteers. The war economy, the draft, the scale of death to come — all of it began with the shock of this single day.

To understand 1861, you have to put yourself inside the expectations of people who had never seen modern war. That skill — judging people by what they knew at the time — is called contextualization.

“The First Battle of Bull Run” — engraving, public domain (Library of Congress).

Into the Minds of 1861

YOUR TURN

You'll step back into the summer of 1861 and use contextualization to explain why intelligent people expected a short war — and why they were so wrong.